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Democrats weigh the known and the new

Tattoo controversy in Maine highlights party's dilemma in choosing candidates

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

Up until recently, Graham Platner embodied the hopes of many Democrats that their party would move away from seasoned, but safe, establishment candidates and try someone different.

Now, the 40-year-old combat veteran and oyster farmer challenging Maine Senator Susan Collins might instead unwittingly provide supporting evidence for Democratic leader Chuck Schumer's plan to win

back the Senate majority by betting on well-known, tried-and-true candidates.

Platner initially earned media buzz for attracting considerable crowds to rallies and for grass-roots donations. But in the past week, various outlets reported he had previously made inflammatory comments on Reddit that included declaring himself a "communist" and disparaging rural voters and police officers. (In multiple interviews, he apologized for the comments, saying

they did not represent his current views.)

The deluge came after Schumer successfully recruited Janet Mills, the 78-year-old, two-term governor of Maine, to run for Collins's seat. The move sparked backlash among a swath of Democrats hungry for new leadership and a fresh approach, a backlash that was only reinforced by the party's blessing of former president Joe Biden's doomed 2024 reelection bid.

Then, on Tuesday, photos circulated online showing Platner with a chest tattoo that matches a well-known Nazi symbol. Platner said he got the tattoo while drunk and on

leave from the military in Croatia and did not know what it represented. He has since gotten it covered.

Later that day, Schumer took the step of publicly endorsing Mills, calling her "the best candidate to retire Susan Collins."

Insurgent candidates might help address Democrats' anxieties over losing ground with segments of the electorate, including men and blue-collar workers, by helping diminish the party's brand of being "too stilted," said Lakshya Jain, a data scientist who cofounded the election analysis outlet Split Ticket.

But the risks of running a candi-

DEMOCRATS, Page A7

US boosts presence in Latin America

Sends aircraft carrier to region; Hegseth describes another boat strike

By Charlie Savage and Eric Schmitt
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has ordered the deployment of the aircraft carrier Gerald Ford as well as its accompanying warships and attack planes to waters off Latin America, the Pentagon said Friday, in a dramatic escalation of military might in the region.

The enhanced US presence "will bolster U.S. capacity to detect, monitor, and disrupt illicit actors and activities that compromise the safety and prosperity of the United States homeland and our security in the Western Hemisphere," Sean Parnell, the Pentagon's chief spokesperson, said on social media.

Parnell did not say when the Ford, the Navy's most modern and technologically advanced carrier, would be moving to the region or where it would be positioned. Navy officials said Friday that the Ford is currently steaming off the coast of

AIRCRAFT CARRIER, Page A6



PHOTOS BY JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Kimberly, 14, rallied Soccer Without Borders players after a practice in East Boston. She joined the program in fifth grade.

Where worry can be sidelined

Amid ICE crackdown, immigrant children find solace in soccer program

By Marcela Rodrigues
GLOBE STAFF

As she juggles the soccer ball in purple and green cleats on an East Boston field, 14-year-old Kimberly feels that she can be herself. She doesn't have to worry about the immigration agents she's been hearing about in the news and at school.

The teen, who moved to the United States from El Salvador at age 4, has found a refuge in a free after-school soccer program run by the nonprofit Soccer Without Borders.

"Being here actually made it a little bit better because I knew that I had a safe place and adults to talk to if anything happens,"



Players competed for the ball during a drill. Soccer Without Borders came to Massachusetts in 2012.

Kimberly said. The Globe is not publishing minors' last names at the program's request.

At a time of increased ICE arrests in the Boston-area, the field means more than just soccer for youths like Kimberly, who is among 1,000 newcomer and immigrant students in the program. As families are having frank conversations with their children about potential arrests, the soccer coaches are trying to make the field a safe place for the children and their families.

The national program, founded in Pennsylvania in 2005, came to the Boston area in 2012. The coaches aim to build students'

SOCCER, Page A10

Healey says food aid at risk for 1m in state

Blames Trump for SNAP loss during shutdown

By Anjali Huynh and Katie Muchnick
GLOBE STAFF AND GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

More than 1.1 million state residents could lose access to federal food benefits beginning Nov. 1 if the government shutdown drags on another week, a dire situation that Governor Maura Healey blamed on the Trump administration.

The US Department of Agriculture, which runs the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, known as SNAP, has instructed states not to process benefits starting in November, according to a letter from Democratic senators this week.

Healey noted that previous administration used leftover money or other funds to continue SNAP benefits during prior shutdowns, and the Center on Budget and Policy Priorities estimates the government has about \$5 billion in a contingency fund that could cover some of the \$8 billion need-

SHUTDOWN
DAY 25

10
Failed Senate votes

Sept. 19
Date of last session

594,048
Workers furloughed

35 days
Longest-ever shutdown

HEALEY, Page A6



Turn over an old leaf

Saturday: Partly sunny. High: 54-59. Low: 43-48.
Sunday: Clouds and sun. High: 52-57. Low: 40-45.
High tide: 2:14 a.m. 2:16 p.m.
Sunrise: 7:09 Sunset: 5:47
Comics and Weather, **D4-5**.
Obituaries, **C9**.

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The demolition of the East Wing of the White House has become Washington's latest tourist attraction, as onlookers witness a historic moment that many said is unsettling. **A2**.

President Trump announced he's ending "all trade negotiations" with Canada because of a television ad. **A4**.

A jury found Irish firefighter Terence E. Crosbie guilty of raping a woman in a downtown Boston hotel last year. **B1**.

A woman who escaped from a burning boat off Cape Cod and was rescued from Naushon Island 30 hours later has died, a family member said. **B1**.

The Social Security Administration's annual cost-of-living adjustment will go up by 2.8 percent in 2026. **D1**.

The NBA betting scandal is the foreseeable result of commissioner Adam Silver's decision to embrace sports betting, writes Gary Washburn. **C1**.

A trick this year: Affording Halloween

Tariffs conspire to drive up costs of candy, costumes, decorations

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

When Angel Iglesias moved to Wakefield with his husband a few years ago, their fiendish Halloween decor — creepy zombie babies, a haunted maze, a butcher table arrayed with a half-torso — became a neighborhood sensation. The best part? They reward brave trick-or-treaters with full-size candy bars.

To pay for it all, Iglesias uses the same analytical approach he employs as an engineer: joining Spirit Halloween's email list for coupons and scanning "Buy Nothing" groups on Facebook for freebies.

Iglesias, 48, even tracked year-over-year prices of bulk candy from BJ's Wholesale Club, Costco, and Amazon on a spreadsheet. What he saw stunned him. Candy prices alone spiked an average of 17 percent, he said. Chocolate prices have jumped even more. He's shelled out more than \$400 on sweets so far.

"When I saw the numbers, I was like,



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Deepanjali Rao tried on a mask at The Garment District in Cambridge.

'Am I crazy? Did I copy and paste wrong?'" he said.

Tariffs are the bogeyman this season, driving up costs, haunting businesses, and

taking a bite out of wallets, said Michele Boylstein, executive director of the New Jersey-based Halloween and Costume Association. **HALLOWEEN, Page A10**

